

Research Interests

- Socially embedded AI systems: responsible and ethical AI, and sociotechnical approaches to model design
- Pluralistic and positive AI alignment: Language technologies that represent diverse human perspectives and support human flourishing
- Alignment operationalization and objective trade-offs; sociotechnical evaluation and benchmarking
- Sociotechnical failures: persuasion, offensive language, stereotypes, and toxicity in LLMs

Education

University of Stuttgart - Institute for Natural Language Processing (IMS)

Stuttgart, Germany

PH.D. IN COMPUTER SCIENCE / NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING

ADVISORS: AGNIESZKA FALEŃSKA, SEBASTIAN PADÓ

2023 - present

DISSERTATION: ALIGNMENT GAPS: NORMATIVE FOUNDATIONS, MODELING CHALLENGES, AND THE DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS OF PREFERENCE LEARNING

University of Stuttgart - Institute for Natural Language Processing (IMS)

Stuttgart, Germany

M.SC. IN COMPUTATIONAL LINGUISTICS

ADVISOR: THANG VU

2020 - 2023

THESIS: PROMPT-BASED LEARNING FOR OPEN-DOMAIN VISUAL QUESTION ANSWERING

Experience

Institute for Natural Language Processing (IMS), University of Stuttgart

Stuttgart, Germany

DOCTORAL RESEARCHER

2023 - present

- Research on pluralistic AI alignment: developing language technologies that represent diverse human perspectives and support human flourishing
- Sociotechnical benchmarking/evaluation of LLMs: pluralistic gaps, persuasion and argumentation, (non-)offensive speech identification, and reward-model preferences
- Lecturer for MSc-level courses: Advanced Deep Learning in Speech and Language Processing, Spoken Dialog Systems, Advanced Topics in LLM Interpretability)
- MSc thesis supervision

Institute for Language, Cognition and Computation (ILCC), School of Informatics, University of Edinburgh

Edinburgh, UK

VISITING RESEARCHER, HOST: BJÖRN ROSS

Aug 2026 - present: Oct 2026

- Research on pluralistic AI alignment, human-label variation, and responsible and ethical NLP

Interaction Lab, Heriot-Watt University

Edinburgh, UK

VISITING RESEARCHER, HOST: GAVIN ABERCROMBIE

Aug 2026 - present: Oct 2026

- Research on pluralistic AI alignment and human-label variation

MilaNLP Lab, Bocconi University

Milan, Italy

VISITING RESEARCHER, HOST: DIRK HOVY

May 2026 - Jul 2026

- Research on pluralistic AI alignment and human-label variation

Mercedes-Benz AG

Sindelfingen, Germany

RESEARCH INTERN, ADVISOR: STEFAN ULTES

Feb 2022 - Jun 2022

- Research on dialog systems (product: Hey Mercedes voice assistant)

Kebun IT AG

Karlsruhe, Germany

RESEARCH INTERN

Oct 2021 - Feb 2022

- Research on speech synthesis for academic and industry applications

Publications

Conference Articles

A Systematic Analysis of Linguistic Features in AI-Generated Text Detection Across Domains and Models

YASSIR EL ATTAR, **ESRA DÖNMEZ**, MAXIMILIAN MAURER, AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

ARXIV:2606.04177

2026

Accepted to the Findings of
AACL-IJCNLP'26

AI Argues Differently: Distinct Argumentative and Linguistic Patterns of LLMs in Persuasive Contexts

ESRA DÖNMEZ, MAXIMILIAN MAURER, GABRIELLA LAPESA, AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE 2025 CONFERENCE ON EMPIRICAL METHODS IN NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING (EMNLP), SUZHOU, CHINA

2025

“I understand your perspective”: LLM Persuasion through the Lens of Communicative Action Theory

ESRA DÖNMEZ AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

FINDINGS OF THE ASSOCIATION FOR COMPUTATIONAL LINGUISTICS: ACL 2025, VIENNA, AUSTRIA

2025

Please note that I’m just an AI: Analysis of Behavior Patterns of LLMs in (Non-)offensive Speech Identification

ESRA DÖNMEZ, THANG VU, AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE 2024 CONFERENCE ON EMPIRICAL METHODS IN NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING (EMNLP), MIAMI, FLORIDA, USA

2024

HNC: Leveraging Hard Negative Captions towards Models with Fine-Grained Visual-Linguistic Comprehension Capabilities

ESRA DÖNMEZ, PASCAL TILLI, HSIU-YU YANG, THANG VU, AND CARINA SILBERER.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE 27TH CONFERENCE ON COMPUTATIONAL NATURAL LANGUAGE LEARNING (CoNLL), SINGAPORE

2023

Peer-Reviewed Workshop Articles

Leveraging Comparable Toxicity Lexicons in Prompt Instructions for Multilingual Text Detoxification

YASSIR EL ATTAR, **ESRA DÖNMEZ**, NINA K. OHLENDORF, AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE 19TH WORKSHOP ON BUILDING AND USING COMPARABLE CORPORA (BUCC), PALMA DE MALLORCA, SPAIN

2026

Preprints

Structuring the Space of Sociotechnical Alignment

ESRA DÖNMEZ AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

ARXIV:2607.01250

2026

Under review

Better Reward Models Are Not Less Biased Ones: Social Alignment Beyond Standard Reward Benchmarks

GAYANE GHAZARYAN AND **ESRA DÖNMEZ**.

ARXIV:2605.05003

2026

Under review

Predicting Objective Conflict and Covering Trade-offs in Steerable Pluralistic Alignment

DAVID TSOI AND **ESRA DÖNMEZ**.

2026

Under review

Teaching

Inside Transformers: Advanced Topics in LLM Interpretability

UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART, IMS — CO-LECTURER

• Seminar on mechanistic interpretability — probing, causal tracing, sparse autoencoders — and its application to unlearning, steering, and safety.

Stuttgart, Germany

Summer 2026

Advanced Deep Learning in Speech and Language Processing

UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART, IMS — CO-LECTURER

Stuttgart, Germany

Winter 2023/24

Spoken Dialogue Systems

UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART, IMS — CO-LECTURER

Stuttgart, Germany

Winter 2023/24

Advanced Deep Learning in Speech and Language Processing

UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART, IMS — TEACHING ASSISTANT

Stuttgart, Germany

Summer 2023

Academic Service

CSS Workshop: AI and Society

Stuttgart, Germany

CO-ORGANIZER, UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART2026

- Brought together researchers from diverse NLP and CSS backgrounds to explore how computational approaches can support the study of social, cultural and institutional questions about AI.

KnitTogether’25

Wildhaus, Switzerland

CO-ORGANIZER, 1ST EUROPEAN CL RESEARCH SUMMIT FOR JUNIOR RESEARCHERS2025

- Brought together 25 early-career researchers for a week-long summit on *Bias in NLP and its Societal Impacts*.

Reviewing

CONFERENCE

ACL Rolling Review (ARR, 2023-2026), Conference on Computational Natural Language Learning (CoNLL, 2023), Language Resources and Evaluation Conference (LREC, 2024-2026), International Conference on Computational Linguistics (COLING, 2024-2026), Konferenz zur Verarbeitung natürlicher Sprache (KONVENS, 2026)

WORKSHOP

EACL Student Research Workshop (EACL SRW, 2025, 2026), Identity-Aware AI (2026), Perspectivist Approaches to NLP (NLPerspectives, 2026)

ETHICS REVIEW

ACL Rolling Review (ARR, 2025-2026)

Honors, Awards & Grants

2025	Outstanding Reviewer Award	IJCNLP-AAACL
2025	Outstanding Reviewer Award	EMNLP